

AFRICAN HUMANITARIAN AGENCY

Foundational Operational Framework 4

Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework

1. Purpose

This framework establishes the strategic and operational basis through which AfHA will strengthen humanitarian capacities and maintain a state of surge readiness in support of Member States, RECs and the wider African humanitarian system. It defines how AfHA will identify capacity gaps, support structured capacity development, establish and maintain surge systems, and ensure that trained personnel, tools and procedures can be mobilised rapidly and effectively when needed. It governs the people, competencies, rosters, simulations, deployment readiness and learning systems required for surge, while the companion frameworks govern the coordination, financing, information, preparedness and advocacy arrangements that enable those capacities to be used effectively.

2. Rationale

The African Humanitarian Agency (AfHA) will only become operationally credible if it is supported by a deliberate and well-sequenced approach to capacity development and surge readiness. The Agency is not being created as a large stand-alone operational responder. Rather, its comparative advantage will lie in strengthening preparedness, supporting coordinated action, mobilising African expertise, and reinforcing the capacities of Member States, Regional Economic Communities (RECs), and partner institutions to anticipate, manage and recover from humanitarian crises. For this reason, capacity development and surge readiness must be treated as mutually reinforcing pillars of AfHA's institutional architecture.

Across the continent, humanitarian response capacity remains highly uneven. Some Member States and regional institutions have relatively well-developed disaster management systems, trained emergency personnel, and established coordination mechanisms, while others continue to face severe constraints in staffing, technical expertise, logistics, information management, emergency financing, and operational procedures. These asymmetries are particularly visible in the early stages of crisis response, when the absence of deployable expertise, clear standard operating procedures, interoperable systems, and pre-identified support arrangements often results in delayed action, duplication, and avoidable losses. In many contexts, national systems are further stretched by the growing frequency of climate-related disasters, conflict-induced displacement, public health emergencies, and compound or cascading risks that exceed routine institutional capacities.

AfHA is intended to help address these gaps, not by replacing national or regional structures, but by creating a continental framework through which capacities can be strengthened, coordinated and mobilised more systematically. This requires two linked investments. First, AfHA must support long-term capacity development across institutional, technical and operational dimensions. This includes strengthening systems, competencies, coordination practices, leadership capabilities, information use, logistics planning, anticipatory action, and humanitarian governance. Secondly, AfHA must establish a credible surge readiness capability so that, when crises occur, trained personnel, technical expertise, coordination support and operational enablers can be mobilised rapidly in support of Member States and RECs.

The rationale for linking capacity development with surge readiness is straightforward. Surge without prior investment in training, standards and systems risks becoming improvised, uneven and unsustainable. Capacity development without surge readiness risks remaining abstract and disconnected from the operational realities of emergencies. A well-designed framework must therefore ensure that capacity development builds the foundations for surge, while surge deployments in turn generate practical learning, strengthen continental solidarity, and inform continuous improvement of training and readiness systems.

This framework is also necessary because AfHA will operate in a highly networked institutional environment. It will need to work with Member State authorities, RECs, Africa CDC, early warning institutions such as AMHEWAS, National Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies, United Nations entities, civil society and local actors. In such a context, readiness depends not only on the capabilities of AfHA's own staff, but also on the extent to which common standards, training pathways, deployment procedures, coordination protocols and mutual support arrangements are

understood across the wider African humanitarian architecture. The framework must therefore support both internal AfHA readiness and broader ecosystem readiness.

Finally, capacity development and surge readiness are essential to AfHA's legitimacy. The Agency will be judged not only by the quality of its frameworks and policies, but by whether it can support timely, professional and context-sensitive action when crises occur. A clear, phased and African-led Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework will help ensure that AfHA grows into a trusted institution with practical value at continental, regional and national levels.

In designing its capacity development and surge readiness architecture, AfHA draws deliberately on the accumulated practice of comparable regional humanitarian coordination and civil protection mechanisms. Several lessons from those experiences are directly relevant. First, a graduated, competency-based certification pathway, in which practitioners are recognised at defined induction, practitioner and specialist levels against a common continental standard, is far more durable than a training catalogue assembled ad hoc: it creates a shared professional language, a portable credential that transcends institutional boundaries, and a clear basis for roster entry and renewal. Second, regular, large-scale simulation exercises, conducted on a predictable cycle and testing the full standby and deployment architecture against realistic scenarios, are the single most effective tool for identifying gaps in procedures, relationships and systems before those gaps matter in a real crisis. Third, deployment readiness must be institutionally embedded, not personally reliant: terms of reference, administrative clearances, duty-of-care arrangements and financial fast-tracks must be ready before a crisis occurs, not assembled under pressure after one begins. Fourth, capacity for anticipatory action requires its own dedicated development pathway, distinct from generic emergency response training, because the skills needed to monitor trigger indicators, validate forecasts, manage playbook activation and conduct post-action review are specialised and must be built systematically. All four of these lessons are incorporated in this framework, adapted to AfHA's mandate, phased development trajectory and African institutional context.

3. Objectives

This framework pursues the following objectives:

- define AfHA's role in capacity development and surge readiness within the African humanitarian architecture
- establish a structured approach to assessing capacity needs at continental, regional and national levels
- define the components of AfHA's internal and external surge readiness system
- support the development of common competencies, training pathways, readiness standards and deployment protocols
- strengthen institutional preparedness across Member States, RECs and AfHA Regional Centres
- promote a culture of continuous learning, simulation exercises, after-action review and operational improvement
- enable rapid, principled and coordinated deployment of African expertise during crises
- align capacity development and surge systems with the other AfHA frameworks, particularly those on coordination, information, financing, preparedness and operational agility.

4. Scope

This framework applies across AfHA's full institutional perimeter and to all partners who contribute to or benefit from AfHA's capacity development and surge readiness system. It covers both long-term institutional capacity development and short-notice surge readiness.

Specifically, the framework applies to the following:

- AfHA Headquarters and Regional Centres
- AfHA staff and secondees

- AfHA surge rosters and standby arrangements
- Member State focal institutions relevant to humanitarian action, disaster management, civil protection and emergency response
- REC and Regional Mechanism structures relevant to preparedness and response
- linked technical institutions, including early warning, public health, logistics and information management actors
- approved partners contributing to capacity development, training, simulation, surge or mutual support arrangements.

4.1 Relationship with companion frameworks

This framework is the capacity and surge readiness framework for AfHA. It defines how people, competencies, rosters, exercises, readiness procedures and deployment learning systems are built and maintained. It does not replace the companion frameworks that define AfHA's coordination architecture, financing instruments, information products, preparedness and anticipatory action procedures, or advocacy pathways. Where this framework refers to those functions, it does so to define the capacity, training, roster or deployment readiness requirements needed to support them.

5. Guiding principles

Seven guiding principles govern AfHA's approach to capacity development and surge readiness. These principles apply to all training, roster, exercise and deployment activities, and they inform the interpretation of every subsequent section of this framework.

5.1 African ownership

Capacity development and surge readiness must strengthen African institutions, African expertise and African-led humanitarian action. External support may be valuable and is actively welcomed in the start-up phase, but it must reinforce rather than displace African capability. This principle has practical implications for how training is designed: curricula should draw on African humanitarian experience and case studies, not simply on global generic content; trainers and facilitators should progressively include African practitioners; and certification standards should be owned and governed by AfHA in consultation with Member States, not licensed from or controlled by external bodies.

5.2 Subsidiarity and complementarity

This framework must respect national leadership and regional mechanisms. AfHA should support and connect capacities rather than create unnecessary parallel systems. Where a member state or REC has existing training, certification or roster infrastructure that meets or can be adapted to meet AfHA's standards, AfHA should recognise and build on it. Where gaps exist, AfHA fills them in coordination rather than in isolation. The complementarity test, established in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework, applies to capacity systems just as it applies to coordination structures.

5.3 Readiness through systems, not only people

Effective readiness depends not only on trained individuals but on procedures, coordination routines, logistics arrangements, information systems, financing mechanisms and leadership clarity. A roster of trained individuals who cannot be deployed because administrative clearances, duty-of-care arrangements and financial fast-tracks are not in place is a readiness gap, not a readiness achievement. This principle requires AfHA to invest equally in the systemic and procedural infrastructure of readiness, not only in training delivery.

5.4 Competency-based development

Capacity development should be linked to clearly defined competencies and operational roles rather than to generic training attendance. A competency-based approach specifies what a trained person should be able to do at the end of a learning pathway, at what level of proficiency, and in which

operational context. This makes training programmes directly useful for roster qualification, deployment tasking and performance assessment. Competency frameworks should be developed in consultation with AfHA's operational leads and with Member States and partners whose staff will be expected to meet them.

5.5 Learning by doing

Simulation Exercises, deployments, peer exchange and after-action review are as important as formal classroom training, and in many cases more important. The most durable capacity is built through repeated application in realistic conditions. AfHA should ensure that every training pathway includes practical application components, that every major simulation exercise generates documented lessons, and that every surge deployment results in a structured after-action debriefing that feeds back into training and procedure refinement.

5.6 Inclusivity

Capacity development and surge systems should intentionally include diverse regions, language groups, professional backgrounds and institutional types. AfHA should monitor the geographic and gender distribution of its training participants, roster members and exercise participants, and take active steps to address under-representation. The inclusion of local and national civil society actors (including traditional authorities and local leaders), where appropriate, is important both for the breadth of expertise in AfHA's network and for the localisation commitments in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework.

5.7 Quality and accountability

Readiness must be measurable. AfHA should maintain clear standards, roster requirements, training records, deployment procedures and performance review processes. Claiming readiness without evidencing it is a reputational and operational risk. Quality assurance and accreditation provisions, described in section 18, provide the accountability framework through which readiness claims are substantiated rather than assumed.

6. Strategic pillars of the framework

The framework is organised around five strategic pillars. These pillars are mutually reinforcing: investment in one pillar creates the foundation for the others. Institutional capacity development provides the governance and systems within which technical capacity functions. Technical and functional capacity provides the expertise that surge rosters comprise. Surge roster development generates the human capital for which readiness systems create the deployment infrastructure. Readiness systems and exercises test and validate the investments made in the first three pillars.

6.1 Institutional capacity development

This pillar focuses on strengthening the organisational capabilities required for humanitarian preparedness, coordination and surge readiness. It includes strategic planning, emergency management procedures, coordination literacy, information use, logistics awareness, resource mobilisation awareness, accountability routines and institutional learning. The formal coordination architecture is governed by Framework 1, while financing systems are governed by Framework 2; this pillar builds the competencies and institutional practices needed to use those systems effectively.

6.2 Technical and functional capacity development

This pillar focuses on the specific technical competencies needed for humanitarian action across all phases of the crisis cycle. These include early warning monitoring and interpretation, anticipatory action, humanitarian information and knowledge management, coordination leadership, logistics coordination, protection-sensitive practice, public health emergency coordination, needs assessment and humanitarian access support. The underlying technical systems are governed by

the relevant companion frameworks; this framework defines the competency pathways and roster roles needed to support them.

6.3 Surge roster development and maintenance

This pillar focuses on identifying, training, certifying and maintaining rosters of deployable experts drawn from AfHA, Member States, RECs and approved partner institutions. A functioning surge roster is not a list of names: it is a managed system of individuals with verified competencies, confirmed availability, current administrative clearances and familiarity with AfHA's deployment procedures. Framework 1 defines when and how surge support is requested and coordinated; this framework defines how the roster is built, maintained and kept deployable.

6.4 Readiness systems and deployment protocols

This pillar ensures that surge capacity can be reliably mobilised when needed. It includes standby arrangements, availability management systems, deployment orders and briefing packs, security and duty-of-care procedures, administrative clearances, financial readiness and logistical support. The financing rules for these mechanisms sit in Framework 2, while this framework defines the readiness procedures and people-facing requirements that allow them to work under time pressure.

6.5 Exercises, simulations and operational learning

This pillar ensures that capacities are tested, validated and continuously improved through structured simulation exercise programmes, scenario planning, deployment debriefs and after-action review. Simulation exercises serve multiple purposes simultaneously: they test procedures under realistic conditions, they build the working relationships that effective coordination depends on, they identify gaps that desk-based planning misses, and they generate the learning record that AfHA needs to demonstrate to Member States and partners that its readiness claims are evidence-based.

7. AfHA's capacity development role

AfHA's role in capacity development is not to become a generic training provider. Its role is to support capacities that are directly relevant to humanitarian coordination, preparedness, anticipatory action, information use, financing readiness, advocacy discipline and surge readiness. This means that AfHA should prioritise practical capacity that allows institutions and individuals to perform defined roles in the AfHA system and in the companion frameworks.

AfHA occupies a specific and bounded role in the African capacity development landscape. It is not a training university, a technical agency or a substitute for the national and regional training infrastructure that Member States and RECs are responsible for maintaining. It is a continental convener, standard-setter, system-strengthener and connector. This role means that AfHA's impact on capacity development is often indirect: it defines standards that others implement, convenes exchanges from which others learn, and creates certification systems that others populate.

AfHA will add value in the following ways:

- identifying common capacity gaps across regions and institutions
- developing continental guidance, competency frameworks and training pathways
- supporting regional and national capacity strengthening through targeted technical assistance and exercises
- linking training to practical readiness and deployment systems
- convening peer learning across Member States and RECs
- ensuring that capacity development contributes to a stronger pool of African deployable expertise.

8. AfHA's surge readiness role

AfHA's surge readiness role is to ensure that support can be mobilised rapidly when a Member State or regional mechanism requires additional capacity. This does not imply a large permanent deployment force. Rather, it implies a layered system of readiness activated through the request, coordination and partner engagement pathways defined in Framework 1, financed through the relevant windows in Framework 2, informed by the products and records defined in Framework 3, and aligned with the preparedness and anticipatory action architecture defined in Framework 5.

AfHA's surge readiness system is layered and collaborative. The layers are not hierarchical in terms of importance; they are sequential in terms of activation. Layer one is the first to be activated, with subsequent layers engaged as the scale or duration of a crisis exceeds the capacity of the preceding layer. This graduated activation logic prevents the over-burdening of any single layer and ensures that the full system is engaged proportionately rather than all at once.

The layered system combines the following:

- a small core of AfHA personnel with defined operational readiness responsibilities who can immediately support coordination, information, liaison and activation processes
- an internal pool of redeployable AfHA staff who can temporarily shift from routine functions to emergency support roles when a crisis requires more capacity than the core team can provide
- regional and continental rosters of trained and certified specialists drawn from Member States, RECs, African institutions and approved partners who can be deployed for defined technical or coordination functions
- secondment and standby arrangements with partner institutions that provide access to additional specific expertise not held in AfHA's own roster, particularly in specialised technical areas
- pre-agreed deployment procedures, support systems and financing mechanisms that ensure the administrative, financial and logistical infrastructure for deployment is ready before crisis conditions create time pressure.

9. Capacity areas to be developed

Capacity development under this framework is organised around seven thematic domains. These domains are not independent of one another: effective coordination depends on good information management; anticipatory action depends on both coordination and preparedness capacity; logistics and operational support depend on administrative and financial readiness. The domains are presented separately for clarity of planning but should be addressed in an integrated way through training design, exercise scenarios and deployment tasking.

9.1 Coordination and humanitarian leadership

This domain covers the competencies needed to use the coordination architecture defined in Framework 1. It includes incident coordination, inter-agency liaison, multi-level coordination between continental, regional and national structures, strategic briefing, meeting management, action tracking and the management of the interface between technical response coordination and political decision-making structures. Leadership capacity in humanitarian coordination is a distinct competency from technical subject-matter expertise: it requires the ability to create clarity, manage disagreement, sustain momentum and hold accountability across a diverse group of actors under pressure.

9.2 Information and analysis

This domain covers the competencies needed to use and support the information architecture defined in Framework 3. It includes data intake and validation, humanitarian situation reporting, common operating picture management, anticipatory trigger interpretation and trigger note production, use of geospatial technologies including Remote Sensing and Geographic Information System (GIS), risk communication, and information sharing with partners at different levels of the system. The anticipatory action dimension of this domain is particularly important: staff responsible for monitoring trigger indicators and interpreting impact-based forecasts need specific

training in the logic and methods of forecast-based action, not only in generic information management.

9.3 Preparedness and anticipatory action

This domain covers the competencies needed to sustain the preparedness systems and anticipatory action procedures described in Framework 5. It includes contingency planning, scenario analysis, hazard-specific planning, trigger condition monitoring and confirmation, blueprint management, readiness reviews, preparedness assessments and early action support. The operational design of preparedness and anticipatory action remains in Framework 5, while this framework defines the training and surge competencies required to implement those procedures. Training in this domain should also address the administrative and documentation requirements of trigger-based financing activation under Framework 2.

9.4 Logistics and operational support

This domain covers the operational competencies needed to support the movement, storage and deployment of people and supplies in humanitarian response. It includes basic humanitarian logistics principles, depot and warehouse management awareness, corridor and access mapping, emergency procurement awareness, supply chain coordination and cross-border facilitation. Framework 1 governs the coordination interface, and Framework 2 governs financing and procurement controls; these frameworks ensure that surge personnel have sufficient logistics literacy to coordinate credibly with specialised logistics partners.

9.5 Public health and multi-hazard coordination

This domain covers the competencies needed to coordinate effectively at the humanitarian-public health interface. It includes an understanding of public health emergency management structures, epidemic-related humanitarian implications, coordination with Africa CDC and national public health authorities, multi-hazard analysis and the specific challenges of compound risk events where a health emergency and a natural hazard or conflict situation interact. As AfHA's mandate spans all hazard types, its coordination staff need sufficient health literacy to engage constructively with public health partners without displacing public health expertise.

9.6 Protection-sensitive and ethical practice

This domain covers the competencies needed to ensure that AfHA's activities respect the protection, dignity and rights of affected populations. It includes protection mainstreaming in coordination, ethical data collection and use, safeguarding and prevention of sexual exploitation and abuse, confidentiality management, community-sensitive communication, and risk-aware coordination practice in conflict-affected settings. Training should align with the information protection provisions in Framework 3 and the humanitarian diplomacy and messaging provisions in Framework 6. Protection is not a specialised addition to humanitarian coordination; it is a dimension of every operational activity.

9.7 Administrative and financial readiness

This domain covers the operational competencies needed to work within the administrative and financial arrangements defined in Framework 2. It includes awareness of delegated authority and approval thresholds, emergency financing drawdown procedures, in-kind support management, documentation and record-keeping requirements, duty-of-care obligations and audit readiness. Framework 2 governs the financial rules; this framework ensures that personnel deployed into surge roles can comply with those rules under crisis conditions.

10. Capacity development modalities

AfHA should use a deliberate mix of capacity development modalities rather than relying on one approach alone. Each modality has distinct strengths and is most effective for specific types of

learning. The most durable capacity is built by combining formal learning with practical application, and individual development with institutional and relational development. AfHA should design its capacity development programmes around learning outcomes rather than delivery formats, and should select the modality mix most appropriate to those outcomes.

10.1 Structured training programmes

Structured training programmes provide baseline and advanced learning linked to defined competencies. They are the foundation of AfHA's certification system and the primary mechanism for establishing common standards across diverse institutions and professional backgrounds. Programmes should be modular, allowing participants to progress through induction, practitioner and specialist levels, and should be available in multiple languages reflecting the linguistic diversity of AfHA's membership. Where possible, training should be delivered through a combination of facilitated residential modules and self-paced e-learning, reducing the time and cost burden on participants and institutions.

10.2 Table-top and functional simulation exercises

Table-top and functional simulation exercises are among the most effective capacity development tools available because they test not only individual competencies but systemic readiness: the procedures, communication flows, decision-making structures and inter-institutional relationships on which effective response depends. AfHA should conduct regular table-top exercises at Headquarters and Regional Centre level and should develop a programme of periodic large-scale multi-actor functional or full simulation exercises that test the entire standby and deployment architecture against realistic multi-hazard scenarios. Simulation exercises should be conducted on a predictable annual or biennial cycle so that Member States and partners can plan their participation in advance. Each exercise should generate a formal after-action report with priority recommendations, and the implementation of those recommendations should be tracked and reported.

10.3 Peer exchange and mentoring

Peer exchange and mentoring programmes allow institutions and practitioners to learn from each other across regions, contexts and institutional types. AfHA should facilitate structured peer exchanges between national disaster management authorities, between RECs, and between AfHA staff and experienced practitioners from comparable mechanisms. Mentoring should be available as a supported pathway for newly appointed coordination staff and newly accredited roster members, pairing them with more experienced practitioners for a defined period following their initial certification. Peer learning is particularly valuable for building the relational capital that effective humanitarian coordination requires: knowing who to call, what to expect from specific partners, and how to navigate institutional sensitivities.

10.4 Embedded technical support

In selected cases, AfHA may provide short-term advisory or technical accompaniment support that helps institutions translate guidance into practice. Embedded technical support is distinct from deployment: it is a capacity development intervention, not an operational one. Its purpose is to strengthen the host institution's own capacity rather than to provide a service that the institution lacks. Each embedded support arrangement should have a defined time limit, a clear capacity transfer plan, and an exit strategy that leaves the host institution more capable than before.

10.5 Deployment-linked learning

Every surge deployment should generate structured learning that is systematically fed back into training programme improvement, SOP refinement, roster development and readiness system adjustment. Deployment-linked learning requires three consistent elements: a pre-deployment briefing that establishes learning objectives alongside operational objectives; a post-deployment debrief conducted within a defined time of return; and a lessons integration process that assigns

specific changes to specific owners with defined timelines. Without this cycle, deployments generate experience for individuals but not institutional learning for AfHA.

11. Surge architecture

AfHA's surge system is structured in four layers. The layers are calibrated to the expected scale and pace of different crisis scenarios: small, fast-moving events draw primarily on Layers 1 and 2; medium-scale or prolonged events progressively engage Layer 3; and large-scale or multi-country events may require the full four-layer system. The architecture is designed to be scalable and additive, not to require all layers to be activated simultaneously for every event.

11.1 Layer 1: Core AfHA readiness staff

This layer comprises Headquarters and Regional Centre personnel who have defined readiness responsibilities as part of their standard roles. They are not deployed away from their normal duty stations; they shift into heightened readiness mode within their existing functions. Their role is to immediately support coordination, information management, liaison and activation processes at the first indication of an emerging crisis. Layer 1 is not a surge capability in the traditional sense; it is AfHA's standing operational capacity in readiness mode. This layer must always be staffed and must always be capable of performing its readiness functions at short notice.

11.2 Layer 2: Internal redeployable capacity

This layer comprises AfHA staff who can temporarily shift from routine functions to emergency support roles when a crisis requires more capacity than Layer 1 can provide. Layer 2 activation is an internal management decision that does not require external procedures. Staff temporarily reassigned under Layer 2 must have sufficient cross-training in emergency coordination, information management or operations support to contribute meaningfully in their temporary role, and must have access to the briefing materials and procedures appropriate to that role. AfHA should maintain a current map of which staff can perform which Layer 2 functions and should test this capacity through internal exercises.

11.3 Layer 3: Continental surge roster

This is AfHA's primary external surge capability. It comprises trained, certified and currently active specialists drawn from Member States, RECs, African institutions and approved partners. Roster members are deployed on an agreed terms-of-reference basis when activated by AfHA in response to a member state or REC request. Layer 3 is the layer that most directly expresses the continental solidarity principle: African experts supporting African responses, mobilised through a common system that AfHA maintains and governs. The design of this layer is described in detail in section 12.

11.4 Layer 4: Partner-linked standby support

This layer provides access to additional specific expertise through formal standby arrangements with partner institutions. It is engaged when the required expertise is not available within Layers 1 through 3, or when the scale of a crisis exceeds the combined capacity of the continental roster. Partner-linked standby arrangements should be documented in formal agreements specifying the types of support available, the procedures for requesting it, the cost-sharing arrangements and the humanitarian principles that govern joint deployment. Layer 4 must not become AfHA's default first resort: its role is to supplement a genuinely functional continental system, not to compensate for a weak one.

12. Surge roster design

AfHA should establish function-based surge rosters that reflect the operational structure of its deployment roles rather than the institutional affiliation of its members. Function-based rosters allow

deployment tasking to match specific operational needs precisely, rather than deploying available people and hoping their skills align with requirements.

Indicative roster functional categories include the following:

- coordination and liaison
- information management and analysis
- logistics and supply support
- public health coordination
- anticipatory action and preparedness support
- protection-sensitive coordination support
- civil-military coordination
- cross-border and regional coordination
- surge team leadership and mission support.

Each roster member profile should record the following information, maintained on a current basis:

- verified competencies by domain and level, linked to certification records
- language proficiency, specifying working languages and level
- institutional affiliation and nomination status
- current availability status and any standing deployment restrictions
- deployment history including dates, roles and performance review outcomes
- current training and certification status with expiry dates where applicable
- security clearance status and emergency travel document readiness
- agreement to AfHA's code of conduct and deployment terms.

Roster membership should be reviewed at least annually. Members who fail to maintain their required training and readiness status should be moved to inactive status rather than remaining on the active roster with outdated credentials. This discipline protects AfHA's operational credibility: a roster that appears well-populated but contains inactive or unqualified members is a planning fiction that will fail at activation.

13. Certification and competency standards

Comparable regional humanitarian coordination mechanisms have demonstrated that a graduated, recognisable certification system is one of the most powerful tools available for building a continental cadre of deployable professionals. A certification system creates a common professional standard that transcends individual institutional boundaries, makes roster qualifications portable and mutually recognisable, provides a clear development pathway for practitioners at different career stages, and gives AfHA a credible basis for assessing who is ready to deploy.

AfHA should develop a continental humanitarian capacity certification framework organised around three levels:

- **Induction level.** The induction level establishes the minimum knowledge and skills required for all AfHA roster members regardless of their functional specialisation. It covers AfHA's mandate, values and operational procedures; humanitarian principles and protection mainstreaming; AfHA's coordination and information frameworks; basic emergency management concepts; duty of care and security awareness; and AfHA's code of conduct. Completion of induction level is a prerequisite for roster entry. It should be deliverable through a combination of self-paced e-learning and a short in-person or virtual residential module.
- **Practitioner level.** The practitioner level covers the domain-specific competencies required for each functional roster category described in section 12. It is assessed against defined performance standards, not merely against attendance at a training course. Practitioners at this level are qualified for deployment in their designated functional role as part of a supervised or supported team. Practitioner certification should be renewable on a defined

cycle, with renewal linked to evidence of continuing development, exercise participation or deployment experience.

- Specialist level. The specialist level recognises advanced expertise and leadership capacity. Specialists are qualified for deployment in senior roles within their functional category, including as team leaders for multi-person surge deployments. Specialist certification should require evidence of deployment experience, peer-assessed performance and, where relevant, contribution to AfHA's training or exercise programmes. Specialists form the core leadership cadre of AfHA's continental surge roster.

AfHA should convene a technical working group including Member States, RECs and experienced partners to develop the detailed competency descriptors, assessment methods and certification procedures for each level, and to review them on a three-year cycle. The certification system should be governed by AfHA with advisory input from this working group, and should be open to recognition agreements with comparable continental and regional certification systems where standards are compatible.

The certification system should be accompanied by a continuing engagement programme that maintains the professional connection of certified roster members between deployments. This programme, analogous to alumni network models used by comparable mechanisms, should include regular newsletters and updates on AfHA's frameworks and procedures, access to peer learning platforms, priority notification of exercise participation opportunities, and a periodic revalidation process that keeps credentials current without requiring repeat full training cycles.

14. Readiness requirements for roster members

Active membership on AfHA's surge roster requires the continuous maintenance of defined readiness standards. Readiness is not a one-time achievement; it is a maintained state that requires ongoing investment by both the roster member and their nominating institution. AfHA is responsible for setting and communicating the readiness standards; Member States, RECs and partner institutions are responsible for supporting their nominated personnel in meeting them.

To remain active on the roster, members must meet the following minimum requirements:

- completion of required induction and technical training
- familiarity with AfHA procedures and humanitarian principles
- confirmation of availability procedures
- security and duty of care orientation
- agreement to deployment terms and code of conduct
- participation in periodic simulations or refresher training.

AfHA should periodically review roster status and move inactive or outdated profiles to inactive status where necessary. In addition to these minimum requirements, AfHA should publish an annual readiness calendar that specifies the training events, exercises and revalidation opportunities available to roster members in the coming year. Publishing the calendar in advance allows nominating institutions to support their personnel's participation through leave planning and travel authorisations, and allows roster members to plan their continuing development alongside their routine professional responsibilities.

15. Deployment readiness system

A roster of certified, available personnel is the human capital component of surge readiness. The deployment readiness system is the institutional and administrative infrastructure that converts a roster entry into a deployed expert through the activation and coordination pathways defined in Framework 1, the financial release and control arrangements defined in Framework 2, and the information and reporting routines defined in Framework 3. Without this infrastructure, the time

between a deployment decision and a deployed team is dominated by administrative work that should have been completed in advance.

The deployment readiness system should include the following components:

- standard terms of reference for each surge role, covering mandate, authority, reporting line, duration, duty station and performance expectations
- deployment order templates that can be issued within hours of an activation decision, with personnel and mission details inserted rather than drafted from scratch
- administrative and travel procedures pre-cleared with AfHA's administrative and legal functions, including visa fast-track approaches where available
- insurance and duty-of-care arrangements confirmed for all roster members before deployment, not arranged after a crisis has begun
- pre-deployment briefing packages maintained on a current basis for each functional roster category, covering the most likely deployment contexts, relevant AfHA procedures and current country or regional context
- post-deployment debriefing procedures including a structured debrief form, a performance review process and a lessons submission process
- financial and procurement fast-track arrangements linked to surge support, consistent with the emergency financing procedures in the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework
- equipment and communications requirements defined by role, with a standing inventory of AfHA-held equipment available for issue on deployment
- security and legal clearance processes confirmed as current for all active roster members, with a defined renewal schedule.

The deployment readiness system should be tested through at least one simulation exercise annually, specifically designed to activate the full deployment procedure from decision to mobilised team under realistic time conditions. The simulation should generate a formal report on the time taken for each administrative step, the bottlenecks encountered and the improvements needed. This is one of the most directly actionable performance measurements available to AfHA.

16. Regionalisation of surge readiness

Continental surge readiness is only as effective as its regional expression. A roster managed entirely from Headquarters, without genuine regional visibility and engagement, will be slow to mobilise, poor in regional context and limited in its coverage of the linguistic, cultural and geographic diversity of the African humanitarian landscape. Regional Centres therefore translate the continental coordination arrangements in Framework 1 into practical surge readiness, training and exercise functions that are grounded in regional realities.

Each Regional Centre should maintain active visibility over the following:

- regional experts and institutions that can support surge
- regional language capacities
- regional logistics and travel realities
- cross-border support arrangements
- likely priority hazard and crisis profiles
- training and exercise needs in the region.

This will allow surge to become more regionally grounded and more responsive to context. Regional Centres should also serve as the primary nodes for regional simulation exercises and for the regional adaptation of AfHA's training programmes. Regional exercises can address hazard types, institutional dynamics and logistical realities that a continental exercise cannot replicate, and they build the working relationships between regional actors that make coordination effective in practice rather than in theory.

17. Relationship with RECs and Member States

AfHA's surge readiness system will only reach its potential if RECs and Member States are co-owners of it, not merely recipients of it. This co-ownership should be built through the partnership and focal point arrangements described in Framework 1, supported by the financing arrangements in Framework 2, and tested through the simulation and review mechanisms in this framework.

Co-ownership implies the following practical commitments from RECs and Member States:

- joint identification of priority competencies
- nomination or secondment of experts to rosters
- participation in exercises and readiness reviews
- agreement on deployment principles and support arrangements
- recognition of existing national and regional capacities that can be connected to the surge architecture.

In return, AfHA's obligations to RECs and Member States in the context of this framework include providing clear certification standards and training pathways that justify their investment in nominating personnel; sharing roster data in a form that allows Member States to understand how their experts are being used; giving member state and REC experts meaningful and non-tokenistic roles in deployments and exercises; and committing to a periodic joint review of the framework's implementation with RECs and Member States as primary participants.

18. Quality assurance and accreditation

AfHA should establish a light but credible system for recognising and verifying readiness. The goal is not an overly bureaucratic accreditation regime but a set of quality assurance practices that make readiness claims evidence-based and that give AfHA, Member States and partners confidence that the people and systems described as ready are genuinely ready.

The quality assurance system should include the following elements:

- core induction completion, verified and recorded before roster entry, with a mechanism for recognising prior learning where equivalent experience can be demonstrated
- functional certification for specific roster roles at practitioner and specialist levels, assessed against defined performance standards as described in section 13
- exercise participation records that document which roster members have participated in which exercises, in what roles, and with what performance assessment
- deployment performance review conducted after each deployment and recorded on the roster member's profile, with a clear escalation path for performance concerns
- periodic roster revalidation on a defined cycle, confirming that active members continue to meet current readiness requirements and that their profiles remain current.

The purpose is not to create an overly bureaucratic accreditation regime, but to ensure that readiness claims are evidence-based. Peer review is an additional quality-assurance mechanism that AfHA should develop over time. A voluntary peer review programme, in which national disaster management authorities or REC mechanisms review each other's preparedness and readiness systems against common AfHA-endorsed criteria, provides a non-coercive mechanism for quality improvement that builds continental standards from within rather than imposing them from above. The peer review approach, adapted from comparable civil protection practice, is consistent with the subsidiarity principle and with AfHA's role as a system-strengthenener rather than a system-replacer.

19. Learning, review and improvement

The capacity development and surge readiness system will only remain relevant and effective if it learns from its own experience. AfHA should establish systematic learning routines that cover every

major element of the system: training delivery, exercise conduct and surge deployment. Learning should not be treated as a retrospective administrative step; it should be built into the design of every training programme, exercise and deployment from the outset.

The framework requires the following learning mechanisms:

- post-training feedback and review: collected systematically at the end of every training event, analysed by the Information and Analysis Lead and acted on within a defined period, with changes to training documented and communicated to participants
- post-exercise review: conducted within a defined period following every table-top or simulation exercise, producing a formal report with prioritised recommendations and a named owner and deadline for each
- deployment debriefs: conducted with every returning roster member within a defined period of return, using a standard debrief form that captures operational experience, procedural gaps, relationship observations and personal wellbeing
- after-action reviews: conducted following every major activation, drawing together deployment debriefs, information function performance data and coordination structure feedback into an integrated operational learning product
- periodic framework refinement: a structured review of this framework and its linked SOPs conducted at least every two years, drawing on accumulated learning from training, exercises and deployments to update standards, procedures and roster design.

AfHA should maintain a lessons register that records learning inputs from all sources, assigns responsibility for action, and tracks implementation. The register should be aligned with the coordination review arrangements in Framework 1, the information records and evidence standards in Framework 3, and the preparedness and anticipatory action learning cycle in Framework 5. It should be reviewed at least quarterly by the relevant operational lead and reported on annually to the Governing Board as part of AfHA's performance reporting.

20. Phased implementation

The implementation of this framework follows the same managed-ambition sequence as the preceding frameworks. AfHA establishes the foundational elements of its capacity development and surge readiness system first, tests and validates them, then expands and deepens them as capacity, partnerships and resources grow. The transitions between phases should be confirmed through structured performance reviews, not assumed on the basis of elapsed time.

Phase 1: Foundational capacity and baseline readiness

In the first phase, AfHA should focus on defining competencies, establishing initial training packages, creating the first roster structures, and putting in place minimum deployment procedures and records.

Priorities in this phase include the following:

- develop the continental competency framework and certification structure described in section 13, with induction level operational by the end of Phase 1
- establish the initial continental surge roster with a manageable number of functional categories and a realistic initial target membership
- put in place the minimum deployment readiness system, including standard terms of reference, deployment order templates, duty-of-care arrangements and briefing packages for the most likely initial deployment scenarios
- conduct at least one table-top exercise at Headquarters level to test activation, coordination and information procedures
- establish the learning and lessons register system
- map existing capacity development infrastructure in Member States and RECs to inform the complementarity approach.

Phase 2: Regional and functional expansion

In the second phase, AfHA should expand regional participation, deepen training, test systems through simulation, and operationalise readiness arrangements with RECs and Member States.

Priorities in this phase include the following:

- expand practitioner and specialist level certification across all functional roster categories
- operationalise regional surge readiness functions in all Regional Centres
- conduct the first multi-actor simulation exercise involving Regional Centres, RECs and Member State representatives
- initiate the peer exchange and peer review programmes with interested Member States and RECs
- test and refine the full deployment readiness system through a simulation designed to activate the complete procedure from decision to mobilised team
- establish the continuing engagement programme for certified roster members.

Phase 3: Mature continental readiness system

In the longer term, AfHA should maintain a stable, tested and reviewed continental system that can mobilise African expertise rapidly and consistently across multiple crisis types.

Priorities in this phase include the following:

- sustain a stable, tested and reviewed continental certification and roster system with known quality and reliability
- conduct regular large-scale simulation exercises on a predictable annual or biennial cycle
- maintain and deepen recognition agreements with comparable regional and continental certification systems
- use accumulated learning from deployments and exercises to continuously refine training content, competency standards and deployment procedures
- demonstrate measurable improvement in surge activation timelines and deployment quality through systematic performance tracking.

21. Risks and mitigation

The following table summarises the principal risks to AfHA's capacity development and surge readiness system and the mitigation measures AfHA will apply. The risk register should be reviewed annually and updated based on operational experience.

Table 1: Risk and mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Training without operational application	Link all training pathways explicitly to roster entry requirements, exercise participation and deployment systems; design every training programme with a practical application component; track the proportion of trained personnel who subsequently participate in exercises or deployments
Overly ambitious roster design	Start with a manageable number of functional categories and a realistic target membership, informed by actual anticipated deployment scenarios; expand gradually as the administrative and quality assurance systems needed to manage a larger roster mature

Risk	Mitigation
Uneven regional participation	Use Regional Centres and structured REC engagement to build balanced geographic and linguistic representation from the outset; monitor distribution data and set regional targets; design exercises to be accessible from all regions
High turnover and loss of trained personnel	Build institutional rather than purely individual capacity; maintain records and refresher pathways so that new entrants can be brought to readiness efficiently; engage nominating institutions as co-owners of the retention challenge rather than treating it as an AfHA-only problem
Surge activated without adequate administrative and financial support systems	Ensure that the deployment readiness system, including administrative clearances, financial fast-tracks and duty-of-care arrangements, is in place before the first operational deployment; test these systems in simulation before first use
Duplication with existing partner capacities	Map existing capacity development and roster infrastructure before building new structures; design AfHA's system to recognise and connect existing capacities rather than duplicate them; establish formal recognition agreements with comparable systems where standards are compatible
Anticipatory action capacity neglected in favour of emergency response training	Explicitly include anticipatory action competencies in the certification framework and competency descriptors; ensure exercises include anticipatory action scenarios, not only acute response scenarios; track the proportion of training investment allocated to anticipatory action capacity

22. Performance indicators

The following indicators provide a minimum framework for assessing the performance of AfHA's capacity development and surge readiness system. They should be tracked on a quarterly basis, reviewed semi-annually through internal management reporting and reported annually to the Governing Board.

Indicative indicators may include:

- number of AfHA and partner personnel trained by competency area
- number of active roster members by region and function
- percentage of roster members meeting current readiness requirements
- number of exercises conducted annually
- average time from surge request to deployment decision
- average time from deployment decision to field mobilisation
- number of deployments completed and reviewed
- proportion of lessons integrated into revised procedures and training
- number of roster members at each certification level by functional category and region
- proportion of roster members with current training, exercise participation and administrative readiness status
- number of simulation exercises conducted annually, with AfHA assessment of whether they met their learning objectives
- time from deployment decision to team mobilised, measured for each deployment and tracked against the target established in the activation SOP
- proportion of training events, exercises and deployments that generated formal learning records integrated into the lessons register

- number of formal recognition or complementarity agreements in place with comparable capacity development or certification systems.

23. Relationship with SOPs to be developed

This framework should be operationalised through a linked set of standard operating procedures. Each SOP translates the procedural provisions of the framework into step-by-step operational guidance for AfHA staff, roster members and partner institutions. These SOPs should be aligned with the coordination activation SOPs under Framework 1, the financing SOPs under Framework 2, the information product and records SOPs under Framework 3, the preparedness and anticipatory action SOPs under Framework 5, and the advocacy and messaging clearance SOPs under Framework 6. The following SOPs are required:

- SOP for capacity needs assessment and competency mapping
- SOP for training, simulation and exercise management
- SOP for surge roster management and maintenance
- SOP for surge activation and deployment readiness
- SOP for secondments and standby arrangements
- SOP for deployment briefing, debriefing and performance review
- SOP for after-action learning and improvement
- SOP for the continental humanitarian capacity certification framework, including competency descriptors, assessment methods and renewal procedures
- SOP for the continuing engagement programme for certified roster members
- SOP for the peer review programme for national and regional preparedness systems

24. Conclusion

The Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework provides the practical bridge between AfHA's institutional ambition and its operational credibility. It recognises that preparedness is built through people, systems, procedures and relationships, and that surge effectiveness depends on prior investment in common standards, readiness routines and African expertise. If implemented consistently, this framework will help AfHA become not merely a coordinating institution on paper, but a reliable continental mechanism that can strengthen capacities before crises and mobilise meaningful support when crises occur.

The framework makes four commitments that are more explicit than most comparable institutional capacity frameworks have been willing to articulate. First, that a graduated, competency-based certification system, rather than a training catalogue, is the correct foundation for AfHA's continental surge roster: certification makes readiness claims verifiable, credentials portable and the development pathway clear for practitioners at every career stage. Second, that the deployment readiness system, the administrative, financial and logistical infrastructure that converts a roster entry into a deployed expert, must be built before the first deployment, not assembled under crisis conditions: the cost of building it in advance is a fraction of the cost of failing to deploy effectively because the infrastructure was not ready. Third, that anticipatory action capacity requires a dedicated development pathway, not an afterthought in generic emergency response training, because the competencies needed to monitor triggers, validate forecasts and manage playbook activation are distinct, learnable and essential to AfHA's most valuable contribution to African humanitarian governance. Fourth, that simulation exercises are not supplementary events in a training calendar but the primary quality assurance mechanism for the entire system, and that their conduct on a regular and predictable cycle, with formal after-action reports and tracked implementation of recommendations, is a core institutional responsibility.

Implementation will be phased and evidence-led. The emphasis on starting with a manageable system, building its quality and reliability, and expanding it as confidence and resources grow is not a concession to resource constraints; it is the correct strategic approach to building a continental system that Member States, RECs and partners will actually trust and use. A small, well-governed

and reliably performing capacity development and surge readiness system builds the institutional credibility that attracts the investment needed to grow. Conversely, an overambitious system that cannot maintain its roster, administer its deployments or learn from its experience will fail precisely at the moments when it is most needed.

Delivered with the same managed ambition and African ownership that govern the preceding frameworks, the system described here has the potential to become one of AfHA's most tangible and most celebrated contributions to the continent: the mechanism through which African humanitarian expertise is recognised, nurtured, mobilised and applied at scale, in support of African people when they need it most.